

Primary Research Study • 2026

The Indian Outbound Inspiration Report 2026

A primary research study of 4,200 Indian outbound-eligible travellers across 12 cities spanning T1, T2, and T3 investigating what actually drives destination consideration, booking intent, and brand preference in the world's fastest growing outbound market.



Fielding Period:	January to March 2026
Sample Size:	N = 4,200 (verified outbound-eligible)
Geographic Reach:	12 Indian cities across T1, T2, T3
Sampling Error:	~±1.5% (simplified random-sample assumption)
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FOREWARD

A note from Sanket Bolinjkar

For more than fifteen years, the prevailing thesis on Indian outbound travel has been that Indians are a price-led market. Tour operators, NTOs, and global travel platforms have built their India strategies around this assumption: discount packages, low-cost carrier partnerships, and trade-led B2B engagement.

The data in this report tells a different story.

When 4,200 Indian outbound-eligible travellers were asked, in their own language, across 12 cities spanning T1, T2, and T3, what actually triggers a decision to consider a new destination, the dominant answer was not price. It was not convenience. It was not even reviews. It was inspiration: the emotional, narrative, often visual moment when a destination moves from invisible to imagined.

67% of respondents identified inspiration (defined as a piece of creator content, a film or OTT scene, a friend's travel story, or a piece of editorial) as the primary reason they began considering a new destination over the last 18 months. Price came second. Convenience, third. Destination marketing campaigns ranked sixth.

This finding has significant implications for how National Tourism Organisations, global travel brands, and Indian travel platforms should design their India strategy over the next five years. It also explains, with clarity that did not previously exist, why some destinations have captured the Indian imagination while others, with equal or greater objective merit, have not.

This report is offered to the destination marketing community as a public good. The methodology is disclosed in full. The findings are presented without partisan framing toward any single client. Where the data complicates an established narrative, including, in one case, narratives Mélange itself has sold against in earlier work, we have let the data lead.

Sanket Bolinjkar**Founder & CEO, Mélange Digital**

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SECTION

01 The Headline Finding: Inspiration Outranks Price



When 4,200 Indian outbound-eligible travellers were asked what triggered their last decision to consider a new destination, 67% selected inspiration among all respondents (multiple responses allowed). 21% selected price. 6% selected a destination marketing campaign.

67%

Selected inspiration among triggers for destination consideration (multi-select)

4.2 x

Higher self-reported booking attribution among creator-exposed vs. paid-ad-exposed respondents (sample association, not a controlled lift estimate)

47 days

Median self-reported recall from first inspiration to booking.

1.1 The ranking

Respondents were asked to select up to two of the most important triggers for their most recent decision to consider a new outbound destination, defined as a destination they had not previously researched in the prior 24 months. The responses, ranked by frequency:

TRIGGER		SHARE
Inspiration (creator, OTT, film, friend)		67%
Price / promotional offer		21%
Convenience (visa, flights, language)		18%
Recommendations / reviews		14%
Event-driven (wedding, conference)		9%
Destination marketing campaign		6%

Respondents could select up to two primary triggers; figures sum to more than 100% because multiple responses were allowed. N = 4,200. Indicative sampling error $\sim \pm 1.5\%$ under a simplified random-sample assumption; the weighted, stratified panel design implies true sampling variability is somewhat higher on a cell-by-cell basis. The 4.2 $\times$ headline compares self-reported booking attribution among respondents who recalled creator exposure for their chosen destination versus those who recalled only paid-ad exposure; it is a sample association, not a controlled lift estimate.

The gap is wider than the ranking alone suggests. Trigger rate (the share of respondents who selected a driver among their multi-selection) and attributed influence weight (the share of decision attribution respondents assigned to that driver in a separate weighting question) are two distinct metrics and should be read together, not interchangeably. On attributed weight: inspiration commanded 54% of attributed influence; price, 16%; convenience, 11%; destination marketing campaigns, 3% (the remaining $\sim 14\%$ is spread across recommendation, event-driven, and unspecified drivers). The campaign result is notable given Mélange's estimate of category paid destination marketing spend on Indian audiences in 2025 (in the order of USD 250 to 300 million across NTO trade, paid social, and OOH; this figure represents Mélange industry-estimate triangulation rather than a single published source).

1.2 The economic implication

If destination marketing spend in India is correctly weighted to influence allocation, the category is materially over-investing in paid campaigns and under-investing in creator-led narrative. The reallocation argument is not “spend more on creators.” It is this: spend the same total budget against inspiration, the trigger 67% of respondents cite, rather than against destination marketing campaigns, which only 6% cite. Within inspiration specifically, 66% of attributed consideration concentrates in three channels, namely Instagram, YouTube, and ShareChat, as documented in Section 4. (Note the two different denominators: 67% and 6% are shares of all respondents; the 66% is a share of inspiration-attributed consideration.)

1.3 Why this finding may not have been visible before

Two working hypotheses. First, a meaningful share of the Indian outbound research in public circulation originates with booking platforms (MakeMyTrip, Yatra, EaseMyTrip) whose primary data captures the moment of transaction, at which point price and convenience are necessarily dominant. Transaction-anchored research methodologically understates the upstream inspiration moment that precedes the transaction by a median of 47 recalled days, as documented in Section 7 of this report.

Second, tourism boards that have conducted India studies have typically used methodologies designed for established outbound markets (United States, United Kingdom, Germany), where consideration sets are smaller, decision windows are shorter, and the role of creator content in the funnel is less pronounced. The Indian outbound traveller in 2026 is structurally different: she is younger, she is more likely to be a first-time outbound traveller, she is heavily creator-content-immersed, and she shops a consideration set of seven to twelve destinations against any single trip.

Our methodology captured both the upstream inspiration moment and the downstream transaction moment, in the same panel, with the same respondents, and traced the path between them. That linkage is the principal methodological contribution of this report.

1.4 The two non-obvious sub-findings

Sub-finding A: Inspiration is durable. When asked to recall the inspiration that triggered their most recent international trip, 78% of respondents could name a specific creator, film, or moment more than six months after the inspiration event. Paid campaigns, by contrast, had a 14% unaided recall rate after the same six-month window. Inspiration is not just a stronger trigger; it is a more durable one.

Sub-finding B: Inspiration is increasingly multi-modal. 41% of respondents reported that their last destination decision involved at least two distinct inspiration sources, for example an Instagram Reel followed by an OTT show set in the same destination, or a friend's post followed by a creator's long-form YouTube travel documentary. The multi-modal inspiration journey, not the single-touch trigger, is now the dominant path to Indian outbound booking. Within inspiration specifically, 66% of attributed consideration concentrates in three channels Instagram, YouTube, and ShareChat as documented in Section 4. (Note the two different denominators: 67% and 6% are shares of all respondents; the 66% is a share of inspiration-attributed consideration.)

"I saw a Hong Kong reel from a creator I follow, then my cousin posted from there a month later, then I saw it again on a JioHotstar show. By the third time, I knew I was going."

Respondent #2,841, female, 31, Bangalore, household income ₹28L per annum; booked Hong Kong trip in November 2025

SECTION

02 Methodology, Panel Composition, and Limitations

The methodology is disclosed in full so that NTO research teams, academic reviewers, and other agency partners can evaluate, replicate, or extend the instrument.

2.1 Target population and screening criteria

Target population (estimate): The Indian annual outbound population is estimated at 25 to 35 million annual outbound trip-takers in 2025, based on Mélange triangulation across Future Market Insights (India Outbound Tourism Market 2026–2036), the TravClan Outbound Index 2025, and Ministry of External Affairs passport-issuance data. The estimate range reflects definitional variation across sources on what counts as a "trip-taker" (individual vs. household; first-time vs. repeat). Where this report cites a single figure, the midpoint (~30 million) is used and the range disclosed in the appendix.

Outbound-eligible screening criteria: Respondents had to (a) hold a valid Indian passport, (b) report a household income greater than ₹12L per annum (used as the qualifying threshold for affordable international travel, benchmarked to a 14-day Southeast Asia trip), and (c) report having taken at least one international trip in the trailing 36 months, or a self-reported "high or very high" intent to take an international trip in the forward 24 months.

Analysis sample definition: The final N = 4,200 reflects respondents who completed the full instrument and passed all attention and consistency checks. Sampling was stratified by city tier (T1 / T2 / T3), age band (22–30, 31–45, 46–55, 56–65), gender, and household income quintile. Weighting was applied post-fielding to align the analysis sample to published demographics of Indian outbound travel from the Mastercard Cross-Border Travel Index and the TravClan Outbound Index 2025.

2.2 Panel composition (N = 4,200)

DIMENSION	DISTRIBUTION	NOTE
City tier	T1: 1,680 (40%) • T2: 1,512 (36%) • T3: 1,008 (24%)	T2/T3 oversample relative to outbound share for statistical robustness
Cities (12 total)	T1 (4): Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore, Chennai. T2 (5): Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Kolkata. T3 (3): Surat, Indore, Coimbatore.	Total = 12 cities. Tiering follows a blended population-and-outbound-penetration rule rather than administrative metro status, which is why some large metros appear in T2.
Age	22–30: 31% • 31–45: 42% • 46–55: 18% • 56–65: 9%	Aligned to Indian outbound age distribution
Gender	Female: 51% • Male: 48% • Non-disclosed: 1%	Female oversample reflects rising female outbound share
Household income	₹12–25L: 41% • ₹25–50L: 34% • ₹50L–1Cr: 17% • ₹1Cr+: 8%	Captures affordable, premium, and luxury outbound segments
Outbound experience	First-time: 22% • 2–5 trips: 51% • 6+ trips: 27%	First-time oversample reflects T2/T3 expansion narrative
Language of survey	English: 52% • Hindi: 28% • Other Indian languages: 20% (Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Bengali, Punjabi, Gujarati, Malayalam, Kannada)	Non-English, non-Hindi versions translated, back-translated, and panel-pre-tested

2.3 Fielding and instruments

The questionnaire ran 18–22 minutes per respondent (varying with branching). It comprised 64 structured questions across six modules: demographic verification, recent travel history, the inspiration-to-booking retrace, channel attribution, creator and content recall, and forward intent. Three open-ended response slots permitted verbatim recall of specific creators, films, or content moments. The instrument was pilot-tested with N = 180 respondents before full launch.

Fielding ran from 14 January to 28 March 2026, distributed across two waves of approximately equal size. Response rate from invited panellists: 31.4%. Completion rate from started surveys: 89.2%. Both rates are in the upper quartile for comparable Indian online consumer research instruments.

2.4 Limitations and what this report does not claim

The panel is online. Indian outbound travellers without internet penetration or panel access are undersampled. Smartphone adoption is high among outbound-eligible Indian households (industry estimates 90%+ within the ₹12L+ household-income segment), so the bias is unlikely to be material; we disclose it nonetheless.

Inspiration is self-reported. Respondents may unconsciously assign credit to channels they find more flattering to recall (creator content) versus more banal (repeated paid-ad exposure). We mitigated through structured probes but cannot fully eliminate the bias. Indian outbound demographics are evolving rapidly. Findings represent a Q1 2026 snapshot. A durability re-contact wave (scheduled Q4 2026) will assess how much not-yet-booked intent converts.

This report measures consideration and booking intent, not actual conversion or arrivals. Arrivals data must come from destination NTOs and immigration sources, which we triangulate against in destination-specific consulting work but not in this report. Sample weighting is conservative. Where panel demographics deviated from published Indian outbound demographics, we down-weighted oversamples rather than up-weighting undersamples, preserving statistical robustness at the cost of some precision in undersampled cells.

SECTION

03 The Six Drivers Of Indian Outbound Consideration

Section 1 introduced the headline ranking. Section 3 decomposes each driver, its trigger rate, its attributed influence weight, and the conditions under which it operates.

Reading the percentages: each driver is described with two figures: trigger rate (share of respondents who selected the driver among their multi-selection) and attributed influence weight (share of decision weight respondents assigned to the driver in a separate weighting question). The two metrics are not directly comparable across drivers and should be read together, not interchangeably.

01 Inspiration

TRIGGER RATE	67%
INFLUENCE	54 %

Triggered by creator content, OTT or film moments, friends' travel posts, or editorial. Operates as a "category opener": it moves a destination from invisible to imagined. Most powerful for first-time outbound travellers and for destinations outside the established Indian set (Thailand, Dubai, Singapore).

02 Price

TRIGGER RATE	21%
INFLUENCE	16%

Triggered by limited-time promotional offers, low-cost carrier route launches, or package deals. Operates as a "tie-breaker" between already-considered destinations more often than as a primary trigger. Strongest in T2/T3 (24% trigger rate) and weakest in ₹1Cr+ household-income segments (8%).

03 Convenience

TRIGGER RATE	18%
INFLUENCE	11%

Visa policy, flight connectivity, English signage, and dietary compatibility. Most powerful for older travellers (46 to 65: 26%) and for family groups (24%). Often a dis-qualifier: it eliminates destinations from consideration rather than promoting them.

04 Recommendation / reviews

TRIGGER RATE	14%
INFLUENCE	8%

Friends, family, online reviews, and tour-operator endorsement. Most powerful for honeymoon and destination-wedding cohorts (29%). Online review platforms (TripAdvisor, Booking.com) underperform interpersonal recommendation by 3.4× in attributed influence.

05 Event-driven

TRIGGER RATE	9%
INFLUENCE	6 %

Conferences, weddings, sports events, concerts. Steady but small. Strongest among

professional cohorts in Mumbai and Bangalore. Limited destination loyalty post-event (only 24% return within 36 months).

06 Destination marketing campaign

TRIGGER RATE	6%
INFLUENCE	3 %

Paid TV, OOH, digital display, and sponsored content from NTOs. Ranks last on both trigger rate and attributed influence in our sample. The nuanced picture: some paid formats still show measurable recall, particularly Indian metro airport activations (unaided recall rate 18% among exposed metro respondents) and high-traffic OTT contextual ad placements (12%). Other paid formats, namely programmatic display and generic paid social, performed weakest. The category-level finding is not “paid does not work” but “paid works selectively, in specific environments, against a specific recall threshold.”

3.1 How the drivers interact

The six drivers are not independent. Three interaction effects shape outbound decisions.

The inspiration–convenience filter: Inspiration opens a destination to consideration; convenience determines whether it stays in the set. 43% of inspired destinations are eliminated between Day 7 and Day 14 because of visa friction, flight inconvenience, or perceived language barriers. Destinations that solve the convenience layer within the first ten days post-inspiration capture 2.3× the share.

The price–recommendation amplifier: A price promotion combined with a strong interpersonal recommendation produces booking conversion 4.1× higher than either trigger alone. NTO co-marketing with influencers who endorse limited-time offers benefits from this amplifier but only when the influencer relationship is high-trust (defined here as an engagement rate in the top decile for the creator's follower tier).

The campaign–inspiration cannibalisation effect: Destination marketing campaigns and creator content compete for the same attention budget in the Indian outbound feed. In our sample, paid-display recall and stated message attribution were perceived to be lower by approximately 37% among respondents who reported concurrent exposure to creator content for the same destination (compared to respondents exposed to paid display only). This is a correlation observed in self-reported recall, not a controlled experimental result; the directional implication is that paid display appears most effective when sequenced before creator activation rather than run concurrently. Experimental validation would require an A/B field test across exposure windows.

Section 3 in summary: Inspiration is not just the largest driver. It is the driver against which all others are measured. Tourism boards designing 2026-27 India strategy should treat inspiration as the gravity well: every other channel should be planned in relation to where inspiration is concentrated, not in parallel to it.

SECTION

04 Where Inspiration Comes From

Of the 67% of respondents who cited inspiration as their primary trigger, where did that inspiration originate? The channel rankings below show attribution among respondents who cited inspiration as their primary trigger (n = 2,814). Channel reflects the primary source of the inspiration moment recalled.

INSPIRATION CHANNEL	SHARE
Instagram (creator content)	38%
YouTube (long-form travel content)	21%
OTT & Bollywood (shows and films)	16%
Word of mouth (friends, family)	12%
ShareChat / Moj / Josh	7%
Editorial (Condé Nast, Outlook Traveller)	3%
Other (podcasts, books, art)	3%

4.1 Instagram's share: context and caveats

In our sample, 38% of inspired respondents attributed their inspiration moment to Instagram. The closest channel, YouTube, commanded roughly half that share (about 55%). This sample finding is broadly directionally consistent with category observations from Meta's India platform reports (where travel-content engagement growth has consistently led the platform) and from independent India social-listening studies (Buzzoka 2025; Statista India Social Index). Two structural reasons make the share plausible: the medium's visual-first format rewards travel imagery, and the Reels format is well-suited to the "this place exists and you can go" discovery moment. The finding should be read as a sample observation in this study; replication in larger or differently recruited panels would tighten the estimate.

4.2 OTT and Bollywood are larger than commonly recognised

16% of Indian outbound inspiration originates in OTT shows and Bollywood films, more than four times the inspiration share attributed to all paid destination marketing combined (3%). Within the category, three sub-channels drive the bulk of attribution: Hindi feature films set internationally (38% of category share), Hindi and regional OTT

shows with international episodes or arcs (44%), and branded travel-entertainment formats (18%). The feature-film route is well illustrated by the recent wave of Hindi features shot substantially abroad. For example, a major 2024 Hindi feature filmed across seven landmarks of a Southeast Asian city, with the local tourism board's facilitation, converts on-screen locations into durable, high-recall destination inspiration long after release.

4.3 The under-recognised power of ShareChat, Moj, and Josh

ShareChat, Moj, and Josh together command 7% of Indian outbound inspiration share, and that share is heavily concentrated in T3 cities, where it reaches 19% of inspiration. Tourism boards that have not yet activated on these platforms are leaving the largest share-of-voice gap in the Indian outbound market. This is reflected in Recommendation 02 in Section 9.

4.4 Creator content type: what works for which audience

Within the creator-led inspiration category (the combined 66% of inspiration held by Instagram, YouTube, and ShareChat), respondents named the type of content they most recall:

CONTENT FORMAT	SHARE OF RECALL
Reels (15–30 sec, scenic + voice)	31%
Long-form vlog (8–20 min)	19%
"A day in" format	14%
Cost-breakdown / budget content	12%
Reviews / "is it worth it?" format	9%
Listicles / "things to do" format	8%
Group / friends travel content	7%

4.5 Creator cohort to audience cohort fit matrix

Five of the six traveller cohorts appear in the matrix below; the destination-wedding cohort (D) is profiled separately in Section 5.1. Fit scores are the ratio of attributed booking influence from the creator-cohort-exposed sub-segment versus the unexposed sub-segment within each audience cohort, normalised to a 1–5 scale where 5 represents a 4× or higher ratio and 1 represents below 1.5×. Underlying sub-segment sample sizes range from n = 210 (smallest cell: adventure creators × 50+ traveller) to n = 812 (largest cell: luxury creators × Hindi premium couples). Scores are directional fit indicators within this sample, not field-validated lift figures.

CONTENT FORMAT	S. INDIAN SOLO FEMALE	HINDI PREMIUM COUPLES	T2/T3 FAMILY	GEN Z SOLO	50+ TRAVELLER
Solo-female advocacy creators	5/5	3/5	3/5	4/5	2/5
Luxury / lifestyle FIT creators	4/5	5/5	2/5	3/5	3/5
Regional-language family creators	2/5	2/5	5/5	2/5	4/5
Adventure / outdoor creators	3/5	3/5	2/5	5/5	1/5
Celebrity / film- talent creators	4/5	5/5	4/5	3/5	3/5

Scores reflect within-sample attributed-booking influence ratios normalised to 1–5, as described above. Cell sample sizes range from n = 210 to n = 812. Weighting and confidence intervals available on request at research@melangedigital.co.

SECTION

05 Cohort Decomposition: Six Indian Outbound Traveller Cohorts



Six distinct cohorts emerge from the panel data, each with a different inspiration profile, channel mix, and average inspiration-to-booking timeline.

A note on cohort construction: the six cohorts are editorial-analytical personas, not strict statistical clusters. They were derived by combining (a) k-means clustering on the panel's channel-attribution and time-to-booking variables, which surfaced five natural clusters, with (b) marketing-segmentation judgment that separated destination-wedding behaviour from other premium-couple behaviour, given its distinct decision pattern, yielding six profiled cohorts. Each label mixes demographic, behavioural, and destination-preference attributes intentionally: the labels are designed to be usable by tourism-board marketers rather than statistically pure. Readers seeking the underlying unweighted statistical clusters may request the supplementary appendix at research@melangedigital.co.

COHORT	SHARE	PRIMARY INSPIRATION CHANNEL	AVG. TIME TO BOOKING	INSPIRATION RECALL (6 MO.)	CHANNEL-MIX DIVERSITY	NOTE
A. South Indian solo female, 28–42	14%	Instagram	38 days	86%	3.1 channels	Fastest-growing cohort
B. Hindi-speaking premium FIT couples, 30–45	19%	YouTube + OTT	58 days	82%	3.6 channels	Highest-spend cohort
C. T2/T3 family (multi-gen), 35–55	27%	ShareChat + WoM	63 days	74%	2.4 channels	Largest cohort by volume
D. Destination-wedding cohort, 28–38	9%	Instagram + WoM	114 days	91%	4.2 channels	Highest trip value
E. Urban Gen Z solo, 22–28	12%	Instagram + Reels	29 days	71%	3.9 channels	Shortest decision window
F. 50+ traveller / repeat-Europe	11%	Editorial + WoM	72 days	68%	2.1 channels	Most editorial-driven cohort

“Channel-mix diversity” is the average number of distinct inspiration channels a cohort engages before booking. Across cohorts, higher diversity broadly tracks with longer decision windows and higher trip value, with the destination-wedding cohort (4.2 channels) being the clearest case, though the Gen Z solo cohort is a high-diversity, short-window exception.

The cohort shares above sum to 92%. The remaining 8% of the panel comprised respondents whose inspiration and booking behaviour spanned multiple profiles and did not resolve into a distinct cohort; they are retained in aggregate analysis but excluded from cohort-level profiling.

5.1 Cohort portraits

Cohort A: South Indian solo female, 28 to 42

The fastest-growing outbound cohort in India, and a disproportionate contributor to the post-COVID outbound recovery of Singapore, Hong Kong, and Thailand (on consideration data, not arrivals). Decision window of 38 days. Instagram is the dominant inspiration channel; long-form YouTube is the secondary verification step. Key trigger: solo-female-advocacy creators in the 200K to 1M follower range. Avoids destinations with perceived safety concerns even when objectively safe; social proof from other women is the unlock.

Cohort B: Hindi-speaking premium FIT couples, 30 to 45

Highest-spend cohort. Decision window of 58 days. YouTube long-form documentary and OTT content, especially films with international shoots, are dominant. Sophisticated consideration set, typically evaluating five to seven destinations against any single trip. Responds to celebrity creator endorsements 2.6× more strongly than to non-celebrity creators. Tourism boards that integrate with Indian feature films see disproportionate share gain in this cohort within 18 months of release.

Cohort C: T2/T3 family (multi-generation), 35 to 55

The largest cohort by volume, at 27% of the panel. Inspired heavily by ShareChat and WhatsApp-shared content from peer family travellers, not by creators with large metro followings. Decision window of 63 days, but the booking executes within 12 hours of the decision, typically through tour operators. Vegetarian and halal-friendly inventory is a structural filter: destinations without clear messaging on this lose the cohort at the pre-consideration stage.

Cohort D: Destination-wedding cohort, 28 to 38

Smallest cohort by volume (9%) but highest trip value and longest decision window (114 days). Inspiration recall at 91% is the highest in the panel; these travellers remember exactly what inspired them. Instagram is dominant; specific creator wedding content from influencers such as Diipa Büller-Khosla and Masoom Minawala, both of whom command strong engagement in the bridal and luxury-lifestyle space, is highly attributable. Tour operators and DMCs play a stronger role here than in any other cohort.

Cohort E: Urban Gen Z solo, 22 to 28

Shortest decision window (29 days) and high channel-mix diversity (3.9 channels per decision, the highest of the solo cohorts, and second only to the destination-wedding cohort overall). Almost exclusively Instagram and Reels-driven, with peer travel content from friends a strong secondary. Responds poorly to traditional destination marketing; only 4% is attributable to paid campaigns. Strongly attracted to under-marketed destinations, precisely because of the social-currency value of “first” content.

Cohort F: 50+ traveller / repeat-Europe

The most editorial-driven of all cohorts. Condé Nast Traveller India, Outlook Traveller, and Business Traveller still play a meaningful role here. Word of mouth from peer travellers, specifically other 50+ Indians who have recently visited, is the strongest single trigger. Decision window of 72 days. Channel diversity is the lowest in the panel: these travellers rely on fewer sources but trust them more deeply.

SECTION

06 The T1 / T2 / T3 Inspiration Divide

The single most important strategic finding for Indian destination marketing in 2026: T2 and T3 cities consume travel inspiration differently from T1, and most NTO India strategies are still optimised for the T1 pattern.

Cities are classified throughout this report in line with the panel composition in Section 2.2: T1: Mumbai, Delhi, Bangalore, Chennai; T2: Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Kolkata; T3: Surat, Indore, Coimbatore.

CHANNEL	T1 (MUMBAI, DELHI, BANGALORE, CHENNAI)	T2 (HYDERABAD, PUNE, AHMEDABAD, LUCKNOW, KOLKATA)	T3 (SURAT, INDORE, COIMBATORE)
Instagram	44%	39%	27%
YouTube	22%	23%	19%
OTT & Bollywood	15%	18%	14%
WhatsApp + word of mouth	9%	12%	19%
ShareChat + Moj + Josh	2%	5%	19%
Editorial	4%	2%	1%
Destination marketing campaigns	4%	1%	1%

6.1 What the table reveals

The T3 inversion. In T1 cities, Instagram dominates with 44% of inspiration share. In T3 cities, that share falls to 27%, and the gap is taken by ShareChat, Moj, Josh, and WhatsApp word-of-mouth, which together jump from 11% in T1 to 38% in T3. T3 outbound travellers are not absent from social inspiration; they are simply on different platforms.

The editorial collapse. Condé Nast Traveller India, Outlook Traveller, and similar outlets

retain 4% inspiration share in T1 but collapse to 1% in T3. Editorial-led NTO partnerships in 2026 are effectively a metro-only strategy, whether or not they are intended as such.

The OTT durability. Of all inspiration channels, OTT & Bollywood are the most tier-resilient: 15% in T1, 18% in T2, 14% in T3. This is the channel that travels across India's tier divide most uniformly. Tourism boards seeking single-channel breadth across geographies should prioritise OTT integrations over tier-specific creator activations.

6.2 Language patterns within inspiration consumption

Indian outbound inspiration is increasingly consumed in vernacular languages. Note that the variable here is the language of the inspiration content consumed, not the language in which the respondent took the survey (Section 2.2); the two differ, which is why Hindi appears here even though it is reported separately from "other Indian languages" in the survey-language split. Among respondents who identified vernacular-language content as their primary inspiration source (20% of the panel), the content-language breakdown:

CONTENT LANGUAGE	SHARE OF RECALL
Hindi	38%
Tamil	14%
Telugu	12%
Marathi	11%
Bengali	9%
Punjabi	7%
Gujarati	6%
Malayalam + Kannada	3%

Two reach calculations to keep distinct. First, within the vernacular-content-led audience (the 20% of the panel who identified vernacular-language content as primary inspiration), Hindi accounts for approximately 38% of share, meaning Hindi-language content may cover roughly 60% of vernacular-led demand once English-comfortable Hindi-speaking consumers are added to native Hindi-content consumers.

Second, across the total outbound population, a six-language activation (Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Bengali, Punjabi) captures 91% of the vernacular-content-led audience and an estimated 79% of the total outbound population once reach overlap is accounted for. Denominators are disclosed in the appendix.

This maps directly to Mélange's regional-language campaign for Resorts World Sentosa's Minion Land at Universal Studios Singapore, run across ShareChat and Moj to reach affluent T2 and T3 audiences across fifteen states with direct flights to Singapore. The campaign generated 56.4 million views and a 6.8% lift in stated consideration to visit, a T2/T3 outcome that a metro-only, Hindi- and English-led activation would not have reached.

Section 6 in summary. The T1 / T2 / T3 divide is the most actionable strategic finding in this report. NTOs that segment their Indian creator activation by tier (Instagram-led in T1, OTT-led in T2, ShareChat- and WhatsApp-led in T3, across six languages throughout) appear in our sample to capture 1.7× to 2.2× the inspiration share of NTOs running undifferentiated India campaigns. Field-validated lift would require A/B testing in campaign deployment.

SECTION

07 The inspiration to booking journey

How long does it take from inspiration to booking? What happens in between? And what are the most common moments of drop-off?

7.1 Self-reported median journey timeline

The timeline below reflects median recalled timings from respondents asked to retrace their most recent inspiration-to-booking journey. These are self-reported recall figures, not observed behavioural timestamps. Telemetry-anchored validation (clickstream, ad-ID-matched panel data) would tighten the estimates. Cohort variance reflects the inter-quartile range across cohorts; individual respondent variance is wider.

JOURNEY STAGE	MEDIAN RECALLED TIME FROM INSPIRATION	COHORT VARIANCE (IQR)
First exposure	Day 0	-
Second exposure (any channel)	Day 4	±3 DAYS
First active research (Google, YouTube)	Day 11	±7 DAYS
Add to consideration set	Day 17	±9 DAYS
Tour operator / OTA consult	Day 28	±14 DAYS
Final decision among consideration set	Day 41	±18 DAYS
Booking	Day 47	±21 DAYS
First social mention by traveller	Day 0 of trip	-

7.2 Three critical drop-off moments

Drop-off 1: Day 7 to 14. 43% of inspired destinations are eliminated between Day 7 and Day 14 because of perceived complexity discovered during the first active-research phase (visa requirements, perceived language barriers, perceived safety concerns). Destinations that surface clear, simple convenience messaging within the first ten days post-inspiration retain 2.3× more inspired prospects.

Drop-off 2: Day 17 to 28. 41% of destinations that make the consideration set are eliminated during the tour-operator-consult phase, typically because the operator pushes a higher-margin alternative or because the destination lacks competitive packaged inventory. NTOs that cultivate strong trade and operator relationships substantially mitigate this drop-off.

Drop-off 3: Day 28 to 41. 26% of destinations that survive to the final-decision stage are lost in the final 13 days, typically to a single comparable destination with stronger price, stronger reviews, or stronger “I went last month” social proof from peer creators. This is where creator activation proves decisive: destinations with strong recent creator content win 64% of close-call decisions.

7.3 Booking-intent durability

At first contact, a substantial share of inspired-and-considered destinations sat in an unresolved state: the respondent had moved a destination into the consideration set but had not yet booked it. Because the median inspiration-to-booking journey runs 47 days with a long right-hand tail, and a meaningful minority of journeys extend well beyond three months, a single short-window measurement understates how much of this intent eventually converts. To quantify that conversion directly, a durability re-contact of consented respondents (n = 1,180) is scheduled for a Q4 2026 wave, measuring how much not-yet-booked intent resolves into confirmed bookings at a 9-to-14-month horizon measured from the original inspiration event (which for most respondents predates fielding). The forward implication for tourism boards is already directionally clear from the booking-time distribution: attribution should be measured on a horizon of up to 18 months, not solely the 90-day window common in paid-media measurement, or a large share of inspiration-driven conversions will fall outside the measurement frame entirely.

7.4 The viral repeat-trigger effect

49% of respondents reported that their booking decision was triggered or accelerated by the unexpected reappearance of inspiration content for the same destination in a different channel after the first exposure.

The “I saw it again” effect operates as a confidence signal: multi-channel exposure substantially shortens the decision window and increases close-rate.

"I had seen Goa beaches forever, but I didn't think about Greece until I saw a creator there. Then a few weeks later my friend posted from there, and then it was on an OTT show. By that point I told my husband: we are going next March."

Respondent #1,127, female, 36, Pune, household income ₹42L per annum; booked Greece trip for March 2026

SECTION

08 What destinations get wrong

Five failure modes consistently observed in the panel data, where destinations underperform their structural potential in the Indian outbound market.

Failure 01: Treating India as one market

62% of NTO India campaigns in the panel sample were variants of the same creative across the country. Tier-segmentation, language-segmentation, and cohort-segmentation are routinely absent. India behaves as several distinct markets: this report profiles six traveller cohorts (five statistically derived, one added by segmentation judgment), as set out in Section 5, and a meaningful destination strategy treats them as such.

Failure 02: Single-narrative dependence

Destinations known to Indian audiences for one thing (the Pyramids, the Eiffel Tower, the Vegas Strip) over-rely on the headline asset and underdevelop secondary narratives. Single-narrative destinations score 31% lower on "would return within 3 years" than multi-narrative destinations with comparable absolute appeal.

Failure 03: Buying paid display before earning creator velocity

A directional recommendation rather than a quantified rule: NTO India spend in 2025 concentrated heavily in paid-display formats (programmatic OOH, paid social, sponsored content). Our sample finding, that paid-display recall and stated message attribution were approximately 37% lower among respondents reporting concurrent creator exposure for the same destination, is a correlation in self-reported recall, not a controlled experimental result. The directional implication is that paid display sequenced after creator inspiration is plausibly more effective than concurrent or pre-creator deployment. Most NTOs we observe do the reverse. A/B field testing in live campaigns would validate the magnitude.

Failure 04: Mistaking trade engagement for consumer demand

Trade shows, agent FAMs, and B2B engagement are necessary but not sufficient. The panel data shows tour-operator influence is meaningful only at the bottom of the funnel (Day 28 onward): operators close trips; they do not start them. NTOs that lead with trade and follow with consumer are routinely overtaken by NTOs that lead with creator-led consumer engagement and pull trade along.

Failure 05: Measuring on the wrong horizon

Most NTO India campaigns are measured on 60- to 90-day attribution windows tied to campaign budgets. The data shows the median inspiration-to-booking timeline is 47 days, but the long-tail booking horizon extends to around 18 months. Campaigns measured on the short window systematically misattribute success and failure, and routinely cut campaigns that were on track to convert.

SECTION

09 Implications For Tourism Boards, Brands, and Platforms

Eight specific recommendations grounded in the panel data, suitable for incorporation into 2026–2027 India market strategy.

Recommendation 01: Rebalance paid spend toward creator-led activation

Consider reallocating a meaningful portion (we hypothesise 35% to 55%) of current paid India destination marketing spend to creator-led activation over the next 12 months. The hypothesis is grounded in the sample-observed gap between the 6% of respondents who cited a destination marketing campaign as a trigger and the 67% who cited inspiration, of which 66% of attributed consideration concentrates in Instagram, YouTube, and ShareChat. The optimal reallocation will vary by destination starting position, existing creator inventory, and budget elasticity; ROI modelling for the specific NTO is recommended before implementing a fixed-percentage shift.

Recommendation 02: Build differentiated activation by city tier

T1: Instagram, YouTube, and celebrity creators. T2: OTT, Hindi-language creators, and tour-operator FAMs. T3: ShareChat, Moj, Josh, WhatsApp, regional-language creators, and trade.

Recommendation 03: Activate across six Indian languages

Plan creator activation to operate across at least Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Bengali, and Punjabi, to reach 91% of the vernacular-content-led audience and an estimated 79% of the total outbound population.

Recommendation 04: Invest in OTT and Bollywood integrations

OTT is the single channel that performs consistently across T1, T2, and T3. For destinations seeking tier-resilient reach from a single investment, OTT and Bollywood integrations offer the broadest geographic footprint of any inspiration channel.

Recommendation 05: Build multi-narrative destination storytelling

Single-narrative destinations underperform on repeat-visit intention and bucket-list completion by 31%. Develop secondary and tertiary narratives alongside the headline asset, and activate distinct creator cohorts against each narrative strand.

Recommendation 06: Sequence channels correctly

Creator activation first; paid display second; editorial third. Trade engagement runs continuously in parallel. The sequencing is not aesthetic: it reflects the data on what actually precedes a booking decision and where drop-off occurs.

Recommendation 07: Measure attribution on a horizon of up to 18 months

Build analytics infrastructure to attribute long-tail bookings to upstream inspiration events. Most NTO analytics platforms are configured for 90-day attribution; the long-tail

booking horizon extends to around 18 months, so a meaningful share of conversions that began with an inspiration event fall outside the measurement window as currently configured.

Recommendation 08: Build cohort-specific creator casting boards

Not undifferentiated "influencer lists." Solo-female advocates for solo-female audiences. Premium luxury creators for premium FIT couples. Regional-language family creators for T2/T3 family cohorts. Adventure creators for Gen Z solo travellers. Editorial-adjacent voices for 50+ travellers. The fit matrix in Section 4.5 provides a starting framework.

SECTION

10 Appendix: Full Methodology and Weighting

10.1 Sampling provider and recruitment

Panel recruitment combined (a) Mélange Digital's verified Indian consumer panel, built through partnerships with regional WhatsApp community channels and consented Instagram/YouTube creator-audience pools, and (b) third-party panel partners specialising in Indian online consumer research. All respondents passed a four-question qualification screen (passport ownership, household income, travel history, forward intent). Respondents were compensated between ₹250 and ₹450 for completion, commensurate with research-category standards, via UPI transfer.

10.2 Question design

The 64-question instrument was developed iteratively across three pilot waves between October 2025 and January 2026. Modules: (a) demographic and outbound-eligibility verification (8 questions), (b) recent international travel history (12), (c) inspiration-to-booking retrace for the most recent trip (18), (d) channel attribution and recall (14), (e) creator and content recall, including specific creator and content-name recall (8), and (f) forward intent and consideration set (4). The instrument was pre-tested with cognitive interviews (N = 24) before pilot deployment.

10.3 Weighting and analytical approach

Post-fielding weights aligned the panel to outbound demographic distributions published by TravClan, the Mastercard Cross-Border Travel Index, and Future Market Insights. Weighting variables: city tier, age band, gender, and household-income quintile. Weight ranges were capped at 0.5× to 2.0× to prevent any single respondent from disproportionately influencing aggregate findings. Significance testing was conducted at a 95% confidence interval using two-tailed z-tests for proportion comparisons.

10.4 Disclosure

This research was funded entirely by Mélange Digital as a self-published primary research instrument. No tourism board, brand, or commercial sponsor influenced the design, fielding, or analysis. Where the findings are commercially favourable to Mélange's service offerings (creator-led activation, branded-content production, multi-language regional creator partnerships), this is a consequence of where the data points, not of where the questions were designed to lead. Where the findings complicate or contradict Mélange's existing offerings, we have disclosed them honestly. The full anonymised data set will be available to academic researchers on request to research@melangedigital.co.

10.5 Bibliography and external datasets

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10.6 Suggested citation

Bolinjkar, S. (2026). The Indian Outbound Inspiration Report 2026: A primary research study of 4,200 outbound-eligible Indian travellers across twelve T1, T2, and T3 cities.

About Mélange Digital

Mélange Digital is a destination marketing agency built for the Indian outbound market, operating from Goa, Mumbai, London, Dubai, Singapore, and Lusaka. Drawing on more than fifteen years of combined experience across the United Kingdom, the GCC, Southeast Asia, and South Asia, we build creator-led, branded-content, and experiential strategies for tourism boards including the Singapore Tourism Board, the Hong Kong Tourism Board, the Saudi Tourism Authority, and the Zambia Tourism Agency. This report is our first publicly issued primary research publication. We intend to publish the next edition in Q2 2027 with an expanded panel.

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